Handler — Game Design Document

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Overview

You never pilot a mech. You run the company: you pick the contracts, spend the money, and command your lances from a handler's console while the war decides what kind of outfit you become.

High concept: a mercenary-company management game with real-time tactical missions, where every contract you accept reshapes your mechs, your pilots, and the political map.

Genre: RTS-lite tactics plus company management, with branching narrative.

Working title: Handler.

Design pillars

1. **Every contract is a bet.** Money is never the only thing on the line. Each job moves your reputation, your relationships, and the story.
2. **Your company wears its history.** Upgrades, pilots, and even mech paint show who you have worked for.
3. **Command from the chair.** You see the battlefield through sensors and pilot reports, not a god camera. Information is a resource.
4. **Pilots are people.** Mechs can be rebuilt. Pilots have loyalties, limits, and memories.
5. **Consequences stick.** Choices ripple forward across the campaign and lead to distinct endings.

Target

- **Platform:** PC first (mouse and keyboard suits RTS control), console later.
- **Audience:** players of Battletech, XCOM, Into the Breach, MechWarrior 5, and Frostpunk who like decisions with weight.
- **Session shape:** one contract plus management takes 20 to 40 minutes. A full campaign takes 20 to 30 hours.

Setting and factions

The game takes place on the frontier world of Kessa, a mining colony whose government collapsed. With no army left, power belongs to whoever has mechs. Rival mercenary companies are carving up the ore fields, and the Kessa Liberation Front is fighting to take the planet back for the people who live there. Your company is small enough to be hired by anyone and threatening enough that no one fully trusts you.

Other mercenary companies hire you as subcontractors, allies, or disposable muscle. They are also your competition: the company that hires you this week may be the one shooting at you next week.

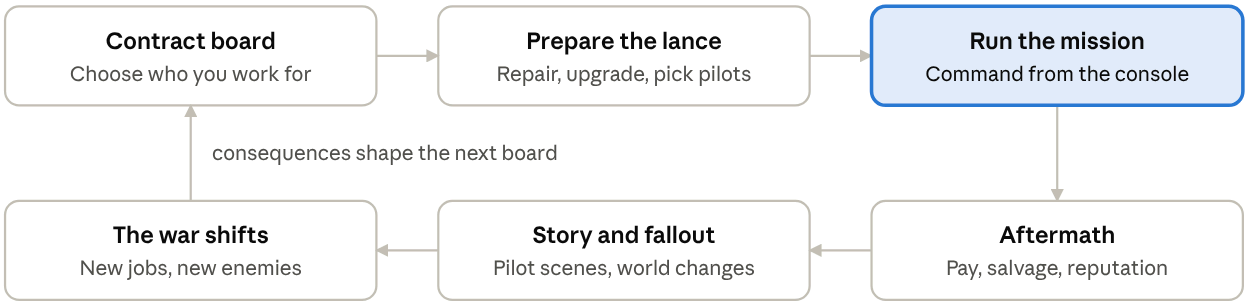
Faction	Who they are	What they pay in	Their tech	What they ask of you
Iron Vultures	The largest merc company on Kessa, run like a corporation	High cash, steady contracts	Licensed, modular, reliable, with remote kill switches	Guard mines, break strikes, push smaller companies out
Kessa Liberation Front	Miners and settlers fighting for independence	Low cash, supplies, safe harbor, recruits	Salvaged and improvised, cheap to repair	Raid merc convoys, defend towns, sabotage the Vultures
Crimson Lance	An elite, disciplined company with a strict honor code	Medium cash, favors, access to veteran pilots	Military-grade armor and sensors	Duels, sieges, and hunting companies that break their word
Black Tide (hidden)	Raiders and smugglers who profit from the chaos	Black-market parts and intel	Overclocked, unstable, untraceable	Jobs that betray other contracts

Black Tide is not on the contract board at first. It reaches out once your company has broken a contract or taken a morally gray job, which gives players a reason to discover it.

Tone: grounded and grimy, closer to a working-class war story than space opera. Mechs are expensive industrial machines that leak oil and need constant repair.

Core gameplay loop

Every contract feeds the next one



core loop · 6 steps, one contract per cycle

One cycle is one contract. What happens in the mission and its aftermath changes which contracts, parts, and pilots show up on the next board.

Contracts

The contract board is the heart of the game. Each contract lists what the client says the job is. The real job is sometimes different.

What a contract shows

- Client faction and contact name
- Objective, location, and deadline
- Pay: upfront advance, completion bonus, and salvage rights (none, partial, or full)
- Estimated enemy strength, which may be wrong
- Reputation shifts with each faction, shown as arrows only until you learn the client better

Contract types

Type	Goal	Twist potential
Escort	Get a convoy from A to B	The cargo is not what the manifest says

Type	Goal	Twist potential
Defend	Hold a position for a set time	The client is late with reinforcements, or never sends them
Raid	Destroy or steal a target	Civilians are nearby
Assassination	Take out a specific enemy mech or commander	The target offers you a better deal mid-mission
Recon	Scan points of interest and get out	You find something a faction wants buried
Salvage	Recover wreckage before rivals arrive	Another merc company shows up

Mid-mission choices

Some missions pause at a key moment and offer a choice, such as "The convoy is carrying prisoners. Continue, release them, or turn them over to the Liberation Front?" Breaking a contract costs the client's trust and your completion pay, but may gain you something else.

Reputation

Each faction tracks your standing from Hostile to Trusted. Standing unlocks better contracts, pilots, and upgrades. Because factions compete, raising one usually lowers another. A second, hidden track called **Company Reputation** measures how reliable you are. Breaking contracts lowers it with everyone, and Black Tide is the only faction that likes a low score.

Mission gameplay

Missions play in real time with pause, from a top-down tactical map on the handler's console. You deploy one lance of up to four mechs, and later two lances at once.

Commands

- **Move, attack, hold, retreat:** standard RTS orders, given per mech or per lance.
- **Stances:** Aggressive, Defensive, or Evasive. These change how pilots act when you are not micromanaging them.

- **Abilities:** each mech has one or two active abilities from its upgrades, such as a jump jet, smoke launcher, or overcharge.
- **Pause and plan:** pause at any time to queue orders. This keeps it approachable for players who are not fast RTS players.

The handler's view

You only see what your mechs' sensors see. Fog of war is heavy, and sensor upgrades matter a lot.

- **Pilot chatter:** pilots report contacts, damage, and panic over the radio. A shaken pilot may misreport enemy numbers.
- **Client intel:** the client may mark targets on your map. Those marks can be wrong or deliberately false.
- **Support purchases:** spend money mid-mission on a recon drone, an artillery strike, or an evac dropship. This keeps the handler role active.

Damage and heat

Mechs have per-section armor (arms, legs, torso) and a heat meter. Firing and sprinting build heat. Overheating shuts a mech down for a few seconds. Leg damage slows a mech, and arm damage disables its weapons. Destroyed mechs leave wrecks you can salvage if you control the field at the end.

Pilot ejection

A mech about to die can eject its pilot. The pilot survives only if you can extract them before enemies reach them, which creates tense rescue moments.

Mechs and upgrades

What your mechs become depends on who you work for. Each faction opens its own upgrade tree, and the parts carry that faction's strengths and strings.

Chassis classes

Class	Role	Speed	Armor	Slots
Scout	Spotting, flanking, recon	Fast	Light	3

Class	Role	Speed	Armor	Slots
Striker	Frontline damage	Medium	Medium	4
Bulwark	Tank and hold ground	Slow	Heavy	5
Artillery	Long-range support	Slow	Light	4

Faction upgrade paths

Upgrades unlock through faction standing, not only money. You can mix parts, but each faction's parts come with a catch.

Source	Strengths	The catch
Iron Vultures	Reliable, easy to repair, strong shields	Kill switch: if you betray the Vultures, they can disable those parts mid-mission
Liberation Front	Cheap, field-repairable, mining tools repurposed as weapons	Lower stats and more frequent breakdowns
Crimson Lance	Best armor and sensors	Marked: Lance rivals target mechs carrying them first, and breaking a Lance contract brings hunters
Black Tide	Highest damage and overclocking	Unstable: chance to overheat or explode, and other factions notice

Visible identity

Mechs show their upgrades visually. Vulture parts are sleek and gray, Liberation Front parts are welded scrap, Lance parts carry red company insignia, and Black Tide parts glow and leak. After a campaign, a player's lance tells their story at a glance.

Salvage

Parts taken from destroyed enemies skip faction requirements, but they arrive damaged and need repair. Salvage lets players build odd hybrid mechs, such as a Lance-armored mech with a Black Tide reactor.

Pilots

Pilots are the company's real assets. Losing a mech costs money, while losing a pilot costs a story.

Pilot stats

- **Skills:** Gunnery, Piloting, and Sensors. These improve with missions.
- **Morale:** rises with wins, pay, and good choices, and falls with losses and orders they dislike. Low morale lowers accuracy and raises the chance a pilot panics or disobeys.
- **Loyalty:** loyalty to you, separate from morale. High loyalty means a pilot follows hard orders. Low loyalty means they may leave or sell you out.
- **Background:** each pilot comes from a faction or place, which shapes their opinions.

Traits

Pilots have one or two traits, such as Hothead (more damage, ignores retreat orders), Cautious (survives more, deals less), Ex-Crimson Lance (refuses to fight the Lance, knows their tactics), or Ex-Black Tide (unlocks black-market contacts).

Lines they won't cross

Some pilots refuse specific orders. A Liberation Front sympathizer ordered to fire on miners might refuse, obey and lose morale, or desert mid-mission and take the mech with them. You learn these limits by playing, and a good handler plans around them.

Between missions

Short barracks scenes give pilots a voice. They argue about contracts, ask for favors, and react to what you did. These scenes are where much of the story is told.

Permadeath

Pilot death is permanent. Survivors remember fallen friends, which can affect their morale and their view of certain factions.

Economy and company management

Money is always tight. The company should feel one bad mission away from trouble, which is what pushes players toward risky or dirty contracts.

Money in

- Contract advances and completion bonuses
- Salvage sold or kept
- Faction favors, such as supplies from the Liberation Front or shared intel from allied companies

Money out

- **Payroll:** pilots and techs are paid every month. Unpaid staff lose morale fast.
- **Repairs:** damaged mechs take days and money to fix. Rushing repairs costs extra.
- **Upgrades:** faction parts and salvage refits.
- **Upkeep:** dropship fuel and base costs.

Time

The campaign runs on a calendar. Contracts expire, repairs take days, and the war moves on without you. Waiting to fully repair means missing good jobs. Deploying damaged mechs is cheaper now and riskier later.

The base

Your dropship is your base. Upgrade its rooms (repair bay, med bay, sensor suite, barracks) to shorten repairs, heal pilots faster, see more about contracts, and hire more staff.

Narrative and endings

The campaign is built in three acts. Your choices decide which faction wins the war for Kessa and what your company becomes.

Structure

1. **Act 1, The Job (about 8 contracts):** small jobs for every faction. Players learn the systems and meet the key characters. The act ends with an event that forces the war into the open.
2. **Act 2, The War (about 15 contracts):** factions compete hard for your services. Their contracts start to conflict, and taking one closes others. Most major choices happen here.

3. **Act 3, The Reckoning (about 6 contracts):** the faction you backed most is close to winning, and the others turn on you. The final missions depend on who you are allied with.

How consequences carry forward

- **World state flags:** destroyed a town, spared a Vulture commander, leaked a Lance contract. Flags change later contracts, dialogue, and available maps.
- **Faction strength:** each faction has a hidden war score. Your contracts shift it, and that decides who controls regions of the map.
- **Returning characters:** people you spared, betrayed, or rescued come back as clients, rivals, or recruits.

Endings

Ending	How you get there	Outcome
Bought Out	Mostly Iron Vultures contracts, high Vulture trust	The Vultures absorb your company. Rich, but owned.
Liberator	Back the Liberation Front through the war	Kessa goes independent, and your company becomes its first defense force.
Brothers in Arms	Earn Crimson Lance trust and keep every contract	The Lance offers you a seat at its table as an equal partner.
Kingmaker	Balance all factions until the end, then choose	You decide the winner in the final battle and name your price.
Ghosts	Black Tide path, low Company Reputation	You disappear with a fortune, hunted by every company on Kessa.
Broken	Lose most pilots or go bankrupt	The company dissolves. An epilogue shows what happened to survivors.

Each ending has variations based on which pilots survived and what they felt about your choices.

UI, art, and audio

The whole game should feel like sitting at a handler's desk: screens, radio static, and paperwork.

UI

- **Diegetic interface:** menus look like the dropship's command terminals. The contract board is a message inbox, and the mech bay is a repair schematic.
- **Mission view:** a tactical sensor map with a clean, readable style, plus small live camera feeds from each mech's cockpit in the corner.
- **Readability first:** enemy threat, heat, and armor must read at a glance, even with heavy fog of war.

Art direction

- Industrial, worn, and practical mechs. Think construction equipment built for war, not sleek anime robots.
- A dusty, ore-red frontier palette, with each faction marked by one strong color: Iron Vultures gray, Liberation Front orange, Crimson Lance red, Black Tide green.
- Stylized 3D with a fixed or rotatable top-down camera keeps asset costs manageable for a small team.

Audio

- Radio chatter is the key audio feature. Pilots' voices carry stress, panic, and humor, and they tell you what is happening.
- Heavy, mechanical sound design: servos, reactor hum, and metal impacts.
- A low-key, tense soundtrack in the base that builds during missions.

Scope and milestones

Build the smallest version that proves the core idea first: one contract whose choice changes what happens next.

1. **Prototype:** one map, one lance of three mechs, one contract with a mid-mission choice. Goal: prove that RTS control from the handler's view feels good.

2. **Vertical slice:** contract board with 5 contracts from 2 factions, basic upgrades from both, pilot morale, and one consequence that carries between missions. Goal: prove that choices feel meaningful.
3. **Act 1 alpha:** all four factions, the full economy, the base, and about 8 contracts. Goal: a playable first act for outside testers.
4. **Full campaign beta:** all three acts, every ending, and balancing.
5. **Launch:** polish, voice work for pilots, and accessibility options.

Features to cut if scope runs long

- Two-lance missions (keep one lance)
- Cockpit camera feeds
- Base room upgrades (replace with simple purchases)
- The Kingmaker ending

Open questions

- [ ] Real-time with pause, or turn-based with simultaneous resolution?
- [ ] Can the player lose the handler character, or only the company?
- [ ] Is the campaign one fixed map of Kessa, or procedurally generated regions?
- [ ] Is there an endless mode after the campaign, where the company keeps taking contracts?
- [ ] Engine choice: Unity, Godot, or Unreal for a small team?